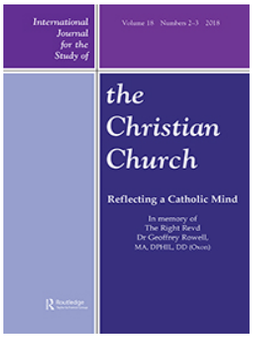

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Mary the Mother of God and ecclesiology: some Orthodox reflections

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ABSTRACT
It is significant that the notion of Virgin Mother occurs in the early centuries in two separate contexts: Mary as Virgin Mother is part of the typological parallelism of Eve and Mary; the Church as Virgin Mother is also found more or less contemporaneously. There is, however, no apparent link between these themes until the end of the fourth century, when texts hitherto interpreted of the Church (notably Psalm 44) begin to be applied to Mary, thus bringing the two traditions together. This early reflection provides a fruitful background to understanding the place of Mary in modern Orthodox ecclesiology. Bulgakov's reflection on Mary is deeply bound up with his sophiology; for Sophia, the Wisdom of God, Mary, the Mother of God, and indeed the Church inhabit what one might call an 'in-between' realm, linking the uncreated God with his creation. Another ecclesiological theme involving Mary occurs in connection with the question: Who is the Person of the Church, as Bride and Virgin Mother? Is this just a personification, or is it more? All the Orthodox theologians discussed in this article, Bulgakov, Lossky and Evdokimov, affirm that the answer to the question 'Who is the Church?' is in fact 'Mary'.

KEYWORDS
Mary; the Church; sophiology; virgin; mother; creation; the 'in-between'; Sergii Bulgakov; Vladimir Lossky; Paul Evdokimov

In the last century, it often seemed as if Orthodox ecclesiology could be summed up under the term 'eucharistic ecclesiology'. While there is no doubt that eucharistic ecclesiology provided a way of reflecting about the institutional nature of the Church in the wake of the collapse of Holy Russia, rendering an institutional ecclesiology bound up with the political notion of *symphonia* between Church and State unviable either for the Russians or for the Œcumenical Patriarchate itself, nevertheless, to regard the concept of eucharistic ecclesiology as exhausting Orthodox reflection on the Church is to miss much that is most vital in Orthodox theology of the last century. One way of opening up deeper dimensions of Orthodox ecclesiology is, I would argue, to consider the relationship between Mary and the Church.

Mary and the Church as Virgin Mother

The earliest reflection about Mary, the Mother of God, occurred in the second century and developed the Apostle Paul's notion of Christ as the Second Adam, supplementing it with the doctrine of Mary as the second Eve. Paul expressed the victory of Christ over death, a victory that extends in principle to the whole human race, by drawing a parallel

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between the first Adam of Genesis 2–3 and Christ as the second Adam. So, for example, in I Corinthians:

> Now Christ has been raised from the dead, the first-fruits of them that slept. For since death came through the human, so through the human came the resurrection of the dead. For just as in Adam all died, so in Christ shall all be made alive (I Cor. 15:20–22).

Paul went on to contrast the 'first man Adam' and the 'last Adam', Christ (I Cor. 15:45). In the second century we find this parallel between the first Adam and Christ the second Adam extended to embrace the first Eve and Mary the second Eve. So, in the *Dialogue with Trypho*, Justin Martyr says that the Son of God

> became man through the Virgin, so that just as disobedience took its beginning from the serpent, so in the same way it might be brought to an end. For Eve, being a virgin and incorrupt, conceiving through the word, gave birth to disobedience and death; Mary taking faith and joy at the glad tidings of the angel Gabriel, because the spirit of the Lord was to come upon her and the power of the most high to overshadow her, and thus the one born of her is the holy Son of God, answered, 'Be it to me according to your word'. And so, this one was born of her, about whom we have shown so many of the Scriptures to speak, through whom God destroyed the serpent and those humans and angels who had become like him.[1]

This expresses the parallel between the virgin Eve, whose disobedience brought death, which was overthrown by the obedience of the virgin Mary. The passage also dwells on Mary's response of faith and joy to the message of the angel as the cause of this reversal of fortune. The same notion is found in other second-century writers, such as Melito of Sardis, Irenaeus and Tertullian. Irenaeus, however, adds a further aspect:

> Just as [Eve] was led astray by an angelic word, so that she fled from God, having betrayed his word, so [Mary] received the good news through an angelic word that she might bear God, obedient to his word. For if [Eve] was disobedient to God, [Mary] was persuaded to obey God, so that the virgin Mary became advocate for the virgin Eve. And just as the human race was bound to death by a virgin, so it was saved by a virgin, virginal disobedience being equally balanced by virginal obedience.[2]

The idea of Mary as advocate for Eve is found again in Irenaeus' *On the Apostolic Preaching*:

> And just as through a disobedient virgin, man was struck and, falling, died, so also by means of a virgin, who obeyed the word of God, man, being revivified, received life . . . . For it was necessary for Adam to be recapitulated in Christ, that 'mortality might be swallowed up in immortality'; and Eve in Mary, that a virgin, become an advocate for a virgin, might undo and destroy the virginal disobedience by virginal obedience.[3]

This makes clear that, for Irenaeus, Mary shares with Christ in the work of recapitulation. She does this as 'Virgin Mother', reflecting her foremother Eve who, in a different way, could also be thought of as Virgin and Mother: created a Virgin, and destined to be the 'mother of all living' (Gen. 3:20). The notion of 'Virgin Mother' is an oxymoron – virgins don't give birth as virgins, and mothers have ceased to be virgins – but in the case of the

[1]Martyr, *Dial. Trypho*, in *Opera*, 100 (Otto, II. 336–8).
[2]Irenaeus, *Adv. Haereses* V. 19. 2 (Harvey, II. 376).
[3]Irenaeus, *Apos. Preaching*, 33 (Behr, 61).

Mother of God, she is precisely 'Virgin Mother', conceiving and giving birth as a virgin, a conviction of the Church that is first found in the second century, to which the mysterious *Protevangelium of James* bears witness: a witness quickly accepted throughout the Church. The notion of 'virgin mother' is also what one might call an 'in-between' notion: between virgin and mother, because both virgin and mother, a unique position, holding together two realms of existence, as it were – the virgin embracing a purity that renders her transparent to God; the mother, inexorably, caught up in the manifold concerns of human living.

The notion of 'virgin mother' is also found in the second century, only this time not explicitly associated with Mary, the mother of Jesus. And not just 'found', but prevalent. For we find in the second-century reflection about the Church as Virgin Mother which, though it makes no explicit reference to Mary, can hardly be regarded as without any such reference at all. The beginnings of such reflection can be traced back to Paul who, just after his only, oblique reference to Mary, when he speaks of God's Son as 'born of a woman, born under the Law' (Gal. 4:4), goes on, in his parable of Abraham's two sons, to identify the heavenly Jerusalem as the 'barren one' of Isaiah's song of the Suffering Servant, who is to break forth into song, because of the abundance of sons she has borne: those who have been born through baptism into Christ's death, the fruits of his passion (cf. Gal. 4:26–31). This notion of the Church as Virgin Mother, 'the barren woman' who as a result of Christ's passion conceives children of God, is picked up by several second-century writers. The Church appears to Hermas as an old woman, old because 'created the first of all things . . . for whose sake the world was established'[4] and then in successive visions as a younger and younger woman, finally '"adorned as if coming forth from the bridal chamber", all in white and with white sandals, veiled to her forehead, and a turban for a headdress, but her hair was white'[5] – picking up another Pauline theme of the Church as a spotless virgin whom the apostle says he will present to Christ (I Cor. 11:2–4). A similar theme is found in *II Clement*, where the assertion in Genesis that God made human kind in his image, making him male and female (Gen. 1:27), has been interpreted of Christ and the Church:

> I do not think that you should be ignorant that the Church is the living body of Christ, for Scripture says, 'God made human kind male and female'; the male is Christ, the female is the Church. Moreover the books and the apostles declare that the Church is not just now, but from the beginning.[6]

This theme is picked up again in Tertullian, who asserts that

> [a]s Adam was a figure of Christ, Adam's sleep was a figure of the death of Christ, who was to sleep a mortal slumber, that from the wound inflicted in his side might be figured the true Mother of the living, the Church.[7]

One of the most striking illustrations of the theme of the Church as the Virgin Mother is to be found in the account of the martyrdom of the Christians in Lyons and Vienne, preserved in Eusebius' *Church History*. The central figure is Blandina, a young

[4]Hermas, *Vision* 2.4.1 [2.8.1] in *Der Hirt* (Whittaker, 7).
[5]Hermas, *Vision* 4.2.1 [4.23.1] in *Der Hirt* (Whittaker 20).
[6]*II Clem*. 14.2 (Bihlmeyer-Schneemelcher, 77).
[7]Tertullian, *De Anima* 43.10 (Waszink, 60).

slave girl, an epitome of weakness for the ancient world. After countless tortures, Blandina was spread-eagled on a post and exposed to the wild animals; she hung there 'in the form of a cross', and by her fervent prayer she encouraged other fellow-Christians who were undergoing persecution. In her suffering with Christ, Christ is manifest to all in Blandina. A day or so later, Blandina is again brought into the arena to be tortured for confessing her faith in Christ. The letter comments that her sufferings and those of her fellow Christians

> were neither idle nor fruitless; for through their perseverance the infinite mercy of Christ was revealed. The dead were restored to life through the living; the martyrs brought favour to those who bore no witness, and the virgin Mother experienced much joy in recovering alive those whom she had cast forth stillborn. For through the martyrs those who had denied the faith for the most part went through the same process and were conceived and quickened again in the womb and learned to confess Christ …[8]

Further torments followed to the final stage when those who remained faithful to Christ were to be dispatched by the sword:

> The blessed Blandina was last of all: like a noble (εὐγενής: well born – and she a slave!) mother encouraging her children, she sent them all before her in triumph to the King, and then, after duplicating in her own body all her children's sufferings, she hastened to rejoin them, rejoicing and glorying in her death as though she had been invited to a bridal banquet …[9]

In Blandina, the slave-girl, there is seen Christ, whose suffering she was sharing, but as a noble mother, encouraging her children, she represents the Church, as Virgin Mother, giving birth to those who had earlier been still-born in their apostasy. These evocations of the Church as Virgin Mother are silent as to the Virgin Mary, and yet the parallel with her whose soul was pierced with a sword, according to Symeon's prophecy, is all but tangible. Not only that: the episode in the fourth Gospel in which Christ gives his mother to the beloved disciple to be his mother, and the beloved disciple to Mary as her son, seems redolent with ecclesiological suggestions, though these are rarely made explicit in the early Church. Such suggestions seemed, however, to Sir Edwyn Hoskyns to be the evident meaning of the episode, for he remarks:

> The Church proceeds from the sacrifice of the Son of God, and the union of the Beloved Disciple and the Mother of the Lord prefigures and foreshadows the charity of the *Ecclesia* of God. Mary, the Mother of the Lord, becomes the mother of the faithful … and the Beloved Disciple here seems to denote the ideal Christian convert.[10]

Mary as virgin mother, the Church as virgin mother: these are to be seen as different aspects of the same truth.

Oddly, though, it takes some time for the dual meaning of the Virgin Mother to be realised, at least explicitly, in the Church. In an immensely rich paper, which sheds much light on the celebration of the Mother of God throughout the Byzantine period, Krastu Banev points to a significant transition that took place at the turning of the fourth century into the fifth.[11] Around this time, there occurred a change in the way in

[8]*Mart. Lyon* 45 (Musurillo, 77).
[9]*Mart. Lyon* 55 (Musurillo, 79).
[10]Hoskyns, *The Fourth Gospel*, II. 631.
[11]Banev, 'Myriad of Names'.

which the images of daughter and queen in Psalm 44: 10–11 were interpreted ('Daughters of kings are in your honour; the queen is present at your right-hand, clothed in many colours, shot through with gold. Hear, daughter, behold and incline your ear, forget your people and the house of your father'). Daughter and Queen are regularly throughout the fourth century interpreted of the Church (Athanasios, in his *Letter of Marcellinus*, is an exception); from the fifth century these images are applied to Mary. I would interpret this less as a radical change, and more as the way in which the imagery of the Virgin Mother who gives birth to Christians through the passion of Christ begins to be seen in a synoptic way: what had previously looked like two traditions of understanding the image of the Virgin Mother, though each silently invoking the other, are now held together. Banev quotes from Proklos, 'the entire miracle of the Virgin birth is hidden in the shadows' (*Hom*. 2.9: quoted Banev, *Myriad of Names*, 93)[12]: it is as if the shadows no longer obscure and divide, but hold together different aspects of the mystery/miracle.

Sergii Bulgakov

When we turn from the patristic period to modern Orthodox theology, we find that the imagery we have already discussed in the patristic period forms the essential background to reflection on Mary and the Church. This is especially true in the theology of Sergii Bulgakov; indeed, one might say that reflection on Mary and the Church is central to Bulgakov's theological vision. This is because both Mary and the Church are deeply entwined in Bulgakov's reflection on *Sophia*, the Wisdom of God: his sophiology. Sophiology had a long tradition in Russian thought, drawing on several traditions – esoteric mystical traditions, associated with names such as Boehme and Angelus Silesius, which constitute one of the sources of German Idealism (or were thought to by Russian thinkers such as Nicolas Berdyaev), strands of the German idealist tradition, especially Schelling, and traditions, peculiar to Russia, that associate the Wisdom of God with the Virgin Mary, both liturgical (Russian Churches dedicated to Holy Wisdom, that observe their dedication on feasts of the Mother of God, her Nativity or her Dormition) and iconographical (in which Wisdom is represented by the Mother of God herself). For Bulgakov the association of sophiology and Mariology is bound up with his concern for what we have already called the 'in-between', the region between God and the created cosmos. Rather than keeping them radically apart, as the Christian doctrine of creation *ex nihilo* can be conceived as entailing, Bulgakov is concerned to explore the frontier between the uncreated God and the created cosmos, a frontier conceived of equally in terms of Sophia and of the Mother of God.

Whatever the immediate roots of sophiology in Western esoteric thought (of which Bulgakov was well aware and made no attempt to disguise; it is interesting to note, while still in parenthesis, that there are scholars today who argue that we cannot go on ignoring the esotericism of such as Boehme, the 'hidden tradition' in Western thought since the Renaissance: I am thinking especially of Michael Martin[13]), God's Wisdom,

[12]Proklos of Constantinople, *Hom*. 2.9: quoted Banev, 'Myriad of Names', 93.
[13]See Martin, *Literature and the Encounter with God in Post-Reformation England, The Submerged Reality: Sophiology and the Turn to a Poetic Metaphysics*, and his anthology of sources: *The Heavenly Country*.

Sophia, as forming the frontier between God and the cosmos is an idea rooted in the Old Testament Scriptures, especially the books of Wisdom: Proverbs, the Wisdom of Ben Sirach, and the Wisdom of Solomon. In these books Wisdom manifests herself as God's co-worker in the task of creation, as well as the route by which human seekers of God find their way back to God by following holy Wisdom. This biblical Wisdom is in between God and the created order. As uncreated Wisdom she manifests God's face to the world; as created Wisdom she leads human kind to God. It is in this context that Bulgakov develops his reflection on the Mother of God. Indeed, sophiology and Mariology are so bound together in his thought that in his late work, *The Orthodox Church* (1935), in which he made a determined attempt to avoid the controversial theses of sophiology, when he came to the Mother of God, he could not but express his thinking in sophiological terms:

> In her is realized the idea of Divine Wisdom in the creation of the world, she is Divine Wisdom in the created world. It is in her that Divine Wisdom is justified, and thus the veneration of the Virgin blends with that of the Holy Wisdom. In the Virgin there are united Holy Wisdom and the Wisdom of the created world, the Holy Spirit and the human *hypostasis*. Her body is completely spiritual and transfigured. She is the justification, the end and the meaning of creation. She is, in this sense, the glory of the world. In her God is already 'all in all'.[14]

Often quoted in this context, by Bulgakov and other Orthodox theologians, is a phrase from St Gregory Palamas' homily on the Dormition, where, towards the end, he speaks of Mary as being alone μεθόριον … κτιστῆς καὶ ἀκτίστου φύσεως, 'frontier between created and uncreated nature'[15]: precisely the role allotted to Sophia by Bulgakov. It is also the role allotted by St Gregory Palamas himself to the divine activities (ἐνέργειαι), or, as he sometimes calls them, powers (δύναμεις). For Bulgakov, Sophia fulfils this role of in-between, μεταξύ: as he put it in his account of his experience of entering the Great Church of Hagia Sophia in Constantinople in January 1923:

> Truly, the church of Hagia Sophia is the artistic, tangible proof and manifestation of Hagia Sophia – of the Sophianic nature of the world and the cosmic nature of Sophia. It is neither heaven nor earth, but the vault of heaven above the earth … this is the μεταξύ of Plato's philosophical intuition.[16]

Sophia, therefore, corresponds to the realm of the uncreated activities of God, and Bulgakov is happy to quote, in support of his own intuitions, Gregory Palamas' assertions:

> If you take away what is in between (μεταξύ) the unparticipated and the participants, you distance us from God, and make out of what binds together in the middle a chasm great and unpassable between (μεταξύ) Him and the generation and arrangement of what has come into being (Triads III. 2. 24).
>
> There is something in between (μεταξύ) what has come into being and that imparticipable beyond-beingness, not one only, but many … (Triads III. 2. 25).[17]

[14]Bulgakov, *The Orthodox Church*, 139.
[15]Palamas, *Or*. 37. 15 (Pseutogkas, 407).
[16]Bulgakov, *Avtobiograficheskie Zametki*, 94–5 (English translation in *A Bulgakov Anthology*, 13–14).
[17]Palamas, *Défense des saints hésychastes*, ed. Meyendorff, II. 686 (both citations).

Whatever complaints may be made about Bulgakov's departure from the tradition of the Church in his sophiology, here he is on firm ground: the 'uncreated energies' of God, Sophia, the Mother of God, the Church – all these embody in some way the in-between, μεταξύ, between the uncreated God and the created cosmos, holding them together, bringing them into contact (the whole question of the 'in-between', the Christianisation of a Platonic theme is something that demands further discussion: apart from the divine activities, Sophia, the Mother of God, the Church, there are several other candidates for inclusion in the in-between, for example, angels and saints, or as symbols of the in-between: icons and, an especially potent symbol, incense, rising like prayer before God).[18]

The assimilation of Sophia to the Mother of God has another important dimension, with profound consequences for ecclesiology, for Sophia stands in relation to God as female to male, as does the Mother of God to her Son (cf. 'Vergine Madre, figlia del tuo figlio').[19] We have already quoted the passage in *II Clement* where the statement in Genesis 1:26 that God made the human 'male and female' is interpreted of Christ and the Church, both having existed ἄνωθεν 'from the beginning' (*II Clem*. 14. 2: Bihlmeyer-Schneemelcher, 77). Bulgakov sees the fullness of the image of God, manifest in both male and female, as realised in Christ *and* his Mother. Male and female, Bulgakov argues, are not simply sex; they are primarily spiritual principles: 'the male is truth in beauty, the female beauty in truth'. He concludes:

> Hence the Lord Jesus Christ, perfect God and perfect human, truly became human and assumed all human nature; in the *image* of his humanity He is joined inseparably with His Most Pure Mother and is *Son* not only thanks to His divinity, as the Only-Begotten of the Father, but also thanks to His humanity as Son of the Mother, born of her by the Holy Spirit.[20]

In her relationship to Christ, Mary in some way echoes the relationship of the Holy Spirit to Christ (who, in the formula often evoked by Bulgakov, proceeds from the Father and rests in the Son: an expression that goes back to St John Damascene): as Christ is God Incarnate, born of the Holy Spirit and the Virgin Mary, so Mary is pneumatophore, bearer of the Spirit. The dyad Christ–Mary is related to, and indeed founded on, the dyad Son–Spirit. What is distinctive about Mary's role in the dyad she forms with her Son is manifest in her feminine qualities: 'This warmth natural to the cult of the Virgin comes from her humanity and her feminine nature' (Bulgakov goes on to comment on the 'coldness of atmosphere of some Protestant churches', which he puts down to a lack of sensitivity to Mary's warmth, and which he associates with Protestant 'forgetfulness' of the Mother of God).[21] Prayer and song addressed to Mary form a large part of Orthodox devotion, both public and private; this Bulgakov sees as a response to her maternal and feminine nature. Bulgakov delights in the image of Mary holding her protecting veil over the world, an image celebrated liturgically on 1 October, the Feast of the Protection/Veil of the Mother of God (the Slavonic *pokrov* meaning both 'protection' and 'veil'). In late Russian iconography, this veil is often

[18]I have made some attempt to discuss this in an article (probably published prematurely): Louth, 'Theology of the "In-Between"', *Communio Viatorum* 55 (2013): 223–236.
[19]Alighiere, *La Divina Commedia, Paradiso*, Canto 33, ll. 1–2 (*Opere di Dante Alighiere*, 1963).
[20]Bulgakov, *The Burning Bush*, 82.
[21]Bulgakov, *The Orthodox Church*, 140.

depicted as an *omophorion*, the broad stole with crosses worn by a bishop (probably a confusion of *maphorion*, veil and *omophorion*); this leads Bulgakov, and others in the Russian tradition, to entertain some sort of participation by Mary in her Son's priesthood (expressed, however, in very guarded tones). Another dimension of Bulgakov's reflection on the Mother of God focuses on the way in which she is not always depicted in relation to her Son (though, in truth, this is quite rare, late and likely to be owing to Western influence). She is called Ἡ Θεόπαις, the 'daughter of God', and in much Orthodox Marian devotion Mary is seen in relation to God as bride, the 'Eternal Bride', as Bulgakov puts it: the refrain of the Akathist Hymn is precisely: Χαῖρε, Νύμφη ἀνύμφευτε, 'Hail, Bride unwedded'. In this way, the Song of Songs is applied to Mary: 'The Song of Songs is also a song about Mary and the Logos, as about every soul seeking its heavenly Groom and joining with Him. The Virgin Mary, Mother of God and Bride of God, is the image of every soul in its relation to the Logos, in its ecclesialization.'[22] Bulgakov goes on to comment that 'this Old Testament Song contains the most New Testament part of the whole canon', and in a footnote comments that the Song of Songs '*is never* read at the Divine Liturgy … At the same time the church's liturgy is saturated with it, its images became the most intimate and usual in ecclesiastical use' (the same is true of the Apocalypse, never read, and yet its imagery is all pervasive, and especially important for Bulgakov).[23] One aspect of Mary's relationship to God is the way in which Bulgakov, along with other Orthodox theologians, sees Mary as in some sense the person of the Church, the person the Church in its relationship to God: 'The Mother of God, as the personal revelation of the Holy Spirit, is the heart of the Church, its so to say personal expression …'.[24]

The dyad of Christ and his Mother plays an important role in Bulgakov's eschatology. In his discussion of the *Parousia*, he is concerned to stress the role of Mary: she is not judged, but pleads with her Son for mercy for the human race – mercy, not forgiveness.[25] Part of the justification of this is, Bulgakov maintains, the iconographic tradition (as at several points in both his Sophiology and his Mariology). Another aspect of this is that, if Mary does not await the *Parousia* as one awaiting judgment, what is her role at the *Parousia*? Bulgakov suggests that she has her own *Parousia*, related to, but independent of her Son's. This *Parousia* (or these *parousiai*?) occurs '*not later* than the *Parousia* of Christ'[26]; that is, before: Bulgakov seems to relate Mary's *parousiai* with her appearances throughout Christian history. These *parousiai* point to the personal relationship Mary develops with those who turn to her, those, like St Sergii of Radonezh and St Serafim of Sarov, who are 'one of her race'. In these *parousiai* and in her pleading with her Son at the Final Judgment, she manifests the role she has achieved as 'Spirit-bearer':

> The heart of the Mother of God, the Spirit Bearer, is pierced by the sword of hell because of her compassionate love; and her maternal intercession is effected starting with the Dread Judgment, which is the beginning, not the end of the judgment. And the 'Mother of God's way of sorrow', revealed to the vision of the Russian people, continues.[27]

[22]Bulgakov, *The Burning Bush*, 103–4.
[23]Ibid., 105, and note 39.
[24]Ibid., *The Burning Bush*, 109.
[25]Bulgakov, *The Bride*, 488.
[26]Ibid., 412.
[27]Ibid., 515.

Bulgakov's last work, *The Bride of the Lamb*, left incomplete, ends with the words:

> She, the Spirit-Bearer, is *Spirit and Bride*, manifesting in Her very being the image of the hypostatic Spirit of God. And about Her it is said in the final words of the New Testament:
>
> 'And the Spirit and the Bride say, Come.
>
> And let him that heareth say, Come!
>
> Even so, come, Lord Jesus!'[28]

Bulgakov's sophiology was, as we have iterated, controversial. It is therefore very striking that among Orthodox theologians who opposed Bulgakov over Sophia (notably, Vladimir Lossky, who composed the indictment of Bulgakov that formed the basis of the *ukaz* of the Moscow Patriarchate), as well as those whose attitude to Bulgakov's sophiology was, at best, ambivalent (e.g., Paul Evdokimov), we find strong parallels to Bulgakov's understanding of Mary and the Church, even more surprising when we recall how deeply entwined Bulgakov's Mariology was with his sophiology.

Vladimir Lossky

Vladimir Lossky's theological *œuvre* is much smaller than Bulgakov's, and even so what he has to say about the Mother of God is quite slender. Nevertheless, despite his opposition to Bulgakov we shall find that they have many themes in common, woven however into a much less rich tapestry.

Many Orthodox discussing Mariology mention the silence of the dogmatic tradition about Mary. Only one title can claim direct conciliar authority, and that is Θεοτόκος, 'Birth-giver of God', popularly, in English, 'Mother of God' (though the claim that the Council of Ephesos of 431 explicitly conferred this title has met recently with scholarly doubt). Other titles, Παναγία, Ἄχραντος, are used in conciliar statements, but rather taken for granted than directly affirmed. This conciliar reticence is taken as acknowledging the mystery surrounding the Mother of God, to be preserved in silence. Almost all Orthodox theologians considering Mary quote (usually in a truncated form) a sentence from St John Damascene's chapter on Mary in his *On the Orthodox Faith*:

> Whence rightly and truly we name the holy Mary *Theotokos*; for this name expresses the whole mystery of the economy.[29]

The succinct conciliar title, then, yields a rich crop: the 'whole mystery of the economy'. This is the first patristic quotation in Lossky's essay, 'Panagia',[30] coming after a meditative recounting of the evidence, largely silent, of the Gospels, in which he brings out the relationship between the person of the Mother of God and the Tradition of the Church, and through this attempts 'to see the glory of the Mother of God beneath the veil of silence of the Scriptures'.[31] For the Damascene, the title *Theotokos* expresses the whole mystery of redemption, because that mystery requires that God be born of a

[28]Ibid., 526.
[29]Damascene, *Exp. fidei* 56 [Latin enumeration: III. 12], lines 37–8: Kotter, 135.
[30]Lossky, *In the Image and Likeness of God*, 195–210.
[31]Ibid., 199.

woman, who is, therefore, truly *Theotokos*, the one to gives birth to God. Lossky's development of John's quotation is somewhat different. For him, the divine economy, which enables the human to participate in the Incarnation, cannot be 'unilateral': 'It is not a matter of the divine will making a *tabula rasa* of the history of humanity.'

> In this saving economy, the Wisdom of God is adapted to the fluctuations of human wills, to the different responses of men to the divine challenge. It is thus that, through the generations of the Old Testament righteous men, Wisdom 'has built her house': the all-pure nature of the Holy Virgin, whereby the Word of God will become connatural with us. The answer of Mary to the archangel's annunciation … resolves the tragedy of fallen humanity.[32]

Lossky makes more of Mary's willing acceptance of God's request than we find in the Damascene; he emphasises her role as co-worker with God. (It is striking that, for all his rejection of Bulgakov's sophiology, Lossky himself brings the Wisdom of God into his account of Mary's role in the divine economy.) Lossky goes on to emphasise how deeply Mary belongs to her heritage in the Old Testament, and notes the way in which Orthodox liturgical texts speak of David as 'the ancestor of God' and Joachim and Anna as the 'holy and righteous ancestors of God'.[33] In common with all Orthodox theologians, Lossky deplores the Catholic dogma of the Immaculate Conception of the Virgin Mary as separating Mary from her Jewish heritage. All of this is directly relevant to the theme of Mary and ecclesiology, for both the insistence on Mary's personal role at the Annunciation, and the emphasis on seeing her as in continuity with the Church of the Old Testament, as the 'beauty of Jacob' (ἡ καλλονὴ Ἰακώβ),[34] are freighted with ecclesiological entailments, Mary's *fiat* at the Annunciation embodying the response to God that lies at the heart of what is meant by the Church, while to see her as part of the Old Testament Church, its fulfilment, as it were, underlines the notion of the Church as (at least) coeval with humanity, as we have found in the earliest Christian reflection on the Church as Virgin Mother.

Lossky makes much, too, of the Eve–Mary parallel ('Eva-Ave') that we have seen goes back to St Justin Martyr and St Irenaeus; Mary can only be understood in relation to the history of humanity, and especially the history of Israel. Lossky also finds a parallel between the Holy Spirit and the Mother of God. He draws attention to the presence of the Mother of God with the disciples after the Ascension, and her presence with the Apostles at Pentecost (often, though not invariably, depicted in the icon of Pentecost): of this he says: 'She who by the power of the Holy Spirit received the divine Person of the Son of God in her womb, now receives the Holy Spirit, sent by the Son.'[35] Mary has a representative role in relation to the Church:

> Only the Mother of God, through whom the Word was made flesh, will be able to receive the plenitude of grace and to attain unlimited glory, by realizing in her person all the holiness of which the Church is capable.[36]

[32]Ibid., 202.
[33]Ibid., 203.
[34]Ledit, *Marie dans la Liturgie*, 32–3, n. 5.
[35]Lossky, *In the Image*, 206.
[36]Ibid., 207.

Mary is all-holy, *Panagia*. In his *Mystical Theology of the Eastern Church*, Lossky discusses what might be called the 'person of the Church'. For him, the Church as the bride of Christ, perfected as one in the Spirit, belongs to the age to come. And he reflects:

> Thus, it would seem that until the consummation of the ages … the Church will have no hypostasis of her own … And yet, to say this would be to fail to perceive the very heart of the Church, one of her most sacred mysteries, her mystical centre, her perfection already realized in a human person fully united to God, finding herself beyond the resurrection and the judgment. This person is Mary, the Mother of God.[37]

Who is the Church? Lossky's answer is: Mary, the Mother of God. This leads us on to another aspect of his Mariology, in which he draws on Palamas' homily on the Dormition:

> Just as when God wished to make an image of all beauty, and to demonstrate his power in this matter purely to angels and humans, he thus made [Mary] all beautiful, and gathering together all the ways in which he had embellished creation, he made her a common world of everything good, both visible and invisible, or rather he revealed her as uniting in herself all loveliness, divine, angelic, and human, as a nobler beauty to embellish both worlds, rooted in the earth, reaching up to heaven and beyond, through her assumption now from the tomb into heaven, uniting things below with things above, embracing the whole of creation with the wonders surrounding her.[38]

Mary, the all-beautiful, unites the divine, angelic and human realms, constituting, as Palamas says later on in the homily (also quoted by Lossky), 'the boundary of created and uncreated nature'.[39]

Paul Evdokimov

Paul Evdokimov, though a little older than Vladimir Lossky, can reasonably be considered after him, as most of his theological *œuvre* was published after Lossky's early death in 1958. In his *L'Orthodoxie* (1959), Mary is treated in one of the sections on ecclesiology, 'L'aspect mariologique de l'Église', though there is reflection on the Mother of God in many other sections; there is a further discussion of Mary in his late essay, 'Panagion and Panagia: The Holy Spirit and the Mother of God' (originally published in 1970, from an incomplete draft on which he was working before his death).[40]

The section in *L'Orthodoxie* begins with the quotation from John Damascene we have already encountered and follows that with a host of patristic references to the Eve–Mary parallel, ecclesiological references to the Church as Virgin Mother in parallel to Mary, and further references in which a parallel is drawn between paternity and maternity, including Cyprian's: 'You cannot have God for your Father if you no longer have the Church for your mother.'[41] He caps this with a liturgical verse:

[37]Lossky, *The Mystical Theology*, 193.
[38]Palamas, *Or*. 35.10 (Pseutogkas, 404); quoted Lossky, *The Mystical Theoogy*, 194.
[39]Palamas, *Or*. 35.15 (Pseutogkas, 407).
[40]'Panagion and Panagia': available in English translation in *In the World, of the Church*, 155–73.
[41]Cyprian, *De Unitate*, 6 (Bévenot, 66–7).

> How can we not wonder at your theandric giving-birth, All-August One? For without having experience of a man, All-Spotless One, you bore in the flesh the Son without a father, him who from before the ages was begotten from the Father without a mother . . . [42]

'To the paternity of the Father in the divine corresponds the maternity of the *Theotokos* in the human, a figure of the *maternal virginity* of the Church.'[43] Along with this goes a parallelism between the Holy Spirit and Mary – evident in the title of the essay – the All-Holy Spirit and the All-Holy Virgin, *Panagion* and *Panagia*. Evdokimov is keen to draw lessons about gender from these parallelisms – Holy Spirit and Mother of God, Mary's virginal motherhood and the Father's divine fatherhood, and draws attention to the parallelism of the divine *fiat* of creation and Mary's *fiat* that enables re-creation – though these parallels are somewhat vitiated by his stereotypical attitudes to gender.

Like most other Orthodox theologians, Evdokimov lays stress on the place of silence in considering the Mother of God, remarking that '[t]he dogmatic precision of the subject of Mary shares in a certain silence the same mystery with the Holy Spirit. Both are relatively late and belong to nearly the same period' (by which he means, I think, the fourth/fifth century).[44] He suggests a difference between 'dogma' and 'dogmatic fact', the latter 'truth experienced liturgically'.[45] In the last words of this essay, reconstructed from his notes after his death, Evdokimov declared:

> It is in this sense – which itself rests upon a hidden revelation – that Mary is the mysterious icon of the Father. The iconographic canons forbid any representation of the Father, who is the Inconceivable and Indescribable One. The Theotokos receives the breath of the Spirit, and her maternity enables us to contemplate in silence the divine Paternity, the face of the Father. A Marian hymn exalts her as the human being who, as the deified new creature, fully participates in the divine being according to grace: 'Let us the faithful sing the Glory of the universe, the door of heaven, the Virgin Mary, Flower of the human race and Theotokos, she who has become heaven and the temple of the divine.'[46]

Evdokimov's reflection on the Mother of God has a lyrical character and moves through a forest of symbols. Without the precision of Lossky, he seems to me to affirm in a similar way that Mary is the person of the Church: from her *fiat* to God's word through the Archangel onwards she embodies the response to God, which lies at the heart of the Church. He quotes one of the *stichera* for Christmas:

> What shall we offer you, Christ, because you have appeared on earth as a human for us? Each of the creatures made by you makes you a thank-offering: the angels a hymn; the heavens the Star; the Magi gifts; the Shepherds their wonder; the earth a cave; the desert a manger; we offer the Virgin Mother. O God before the ages, have mercy on us.[47]

Mary is our offering – the offering of the human race – to Christ. In the chapter in *L'Orthodoxie*, Evdokimov asserts:

[42]Dogmatikon for Saturday vespers in tone 3 (*Paraklitiki*, 251).
[43]Evdokimov, *L'Orthodoxie*, 149.
[44]Evdokimov, *In the World*, 165.
[45]Ibid., 166.
[46]Ibid., 173.
[47]Last *sticheron*, Vespers, 26 December (*Menaion [December]*, 524).

> It is her humanity, her flesh, that becomes that of Christ, the Mother becomes 'consanguineous' with him, and she is the first to realize the final end for which the world has been created: 'the boundary of the created and the uncreated' (St Gregory Palamas), and through her 'the Trinity is glorified' (St Cyril of Alexandria). In giving birth to Christ, as the universal Eve, she gives birth for *all*, and thus gives birth to him also in every soul: that is why the whole Church 'rejoices in the blessed Virgin' (St Ephrem). The Church, therefore, in her function as mystic matrix, is the type of the continual giving birth, of the *perpetual Theotokos*.[48]

And elsewhere Evdokimov remarks that 'The breath of giving birth, in the expression of Fr Sergius Bulgakov, is the Spirit's "hypostatic maternity". This is why the virginal maternity of the Theotokos, according to Tradition, is a figure of the Holy Spirit, the Advocate.'[49] Equally, then, in some sense, Mary can be seen as the *hypostasis* of the Church, the person the Church is, as Lossky maintained.

Conclusion

We have seen enough in the few theologians of the Russian Orthodox tradition that we have discussed to assert that there is a great deal more to Orthodox ecclesiology than 'eucharistic ecclesiology'. Not only that, the few theologians through whom we have explored the relationship between Mary the Mother of God and the doctrine of the Church were contemporary with those who promoted the notion of 'eucharistic ecclesiology' within Orthodox theology: something that makes all the more surprising the amnesia under which their ecclesiological notions seem to have fallen.

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[48]Evdokimov, *L'Orthodoxie*, 151.
[49]Evdokimov, *In the World*, 161.

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